# First Inaugural Address

*President Barack Obama · January 20, 2009*

*Source: Barack Obama, First Inaugural Address (2009). Public domain. Continuous passage.*

> Sworn in amid financial crisis and two wars as the first African American president, Obama called for “a new era of responsibility,” hope over fear, and a renewal of America's founding ideals.

On this day, we gather because we have chosen hope over fear, unity of purpose over conflict and discord. On this day, we come to proclaim an end to the petty grievances and false promises, the recriminations and worn out dogmas, that for far too long have strangled our politics.

[ . . . ]

The question we ask today is not whether our government is too big or too small, but whether it works — whether it helps families find jobs at a decent wage, care they can afford, a retirement that is dignified. Where the answer is yes, we intend to move forward. Where the answer is no, programs will end.